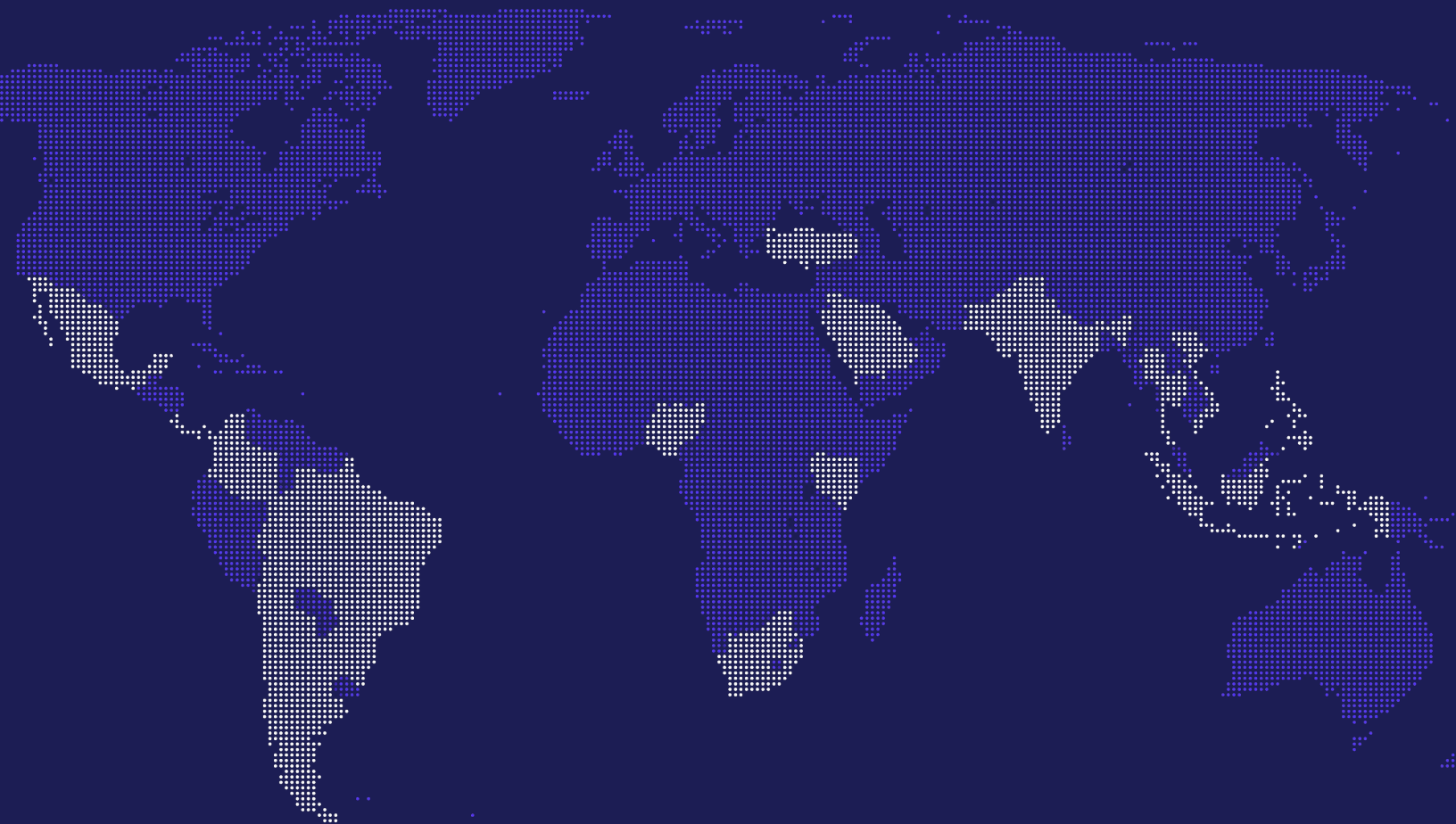




stripe



Report

Workers across the platform economy are fueling demand for stablecoins

The case for paying global workers in stablecoins

Global platforms and marketplaces face persistent challenges paying workers across borders: high fees, slow settlement, and fragmented financial infrastructure that varies by region. These problems are exacerbated in emerging markets that struggle with currency fluctuations, inefficient banking rails, and unreliable payments. For platforms competing for talent internationally, these technical frictions are also growth and retention risks.

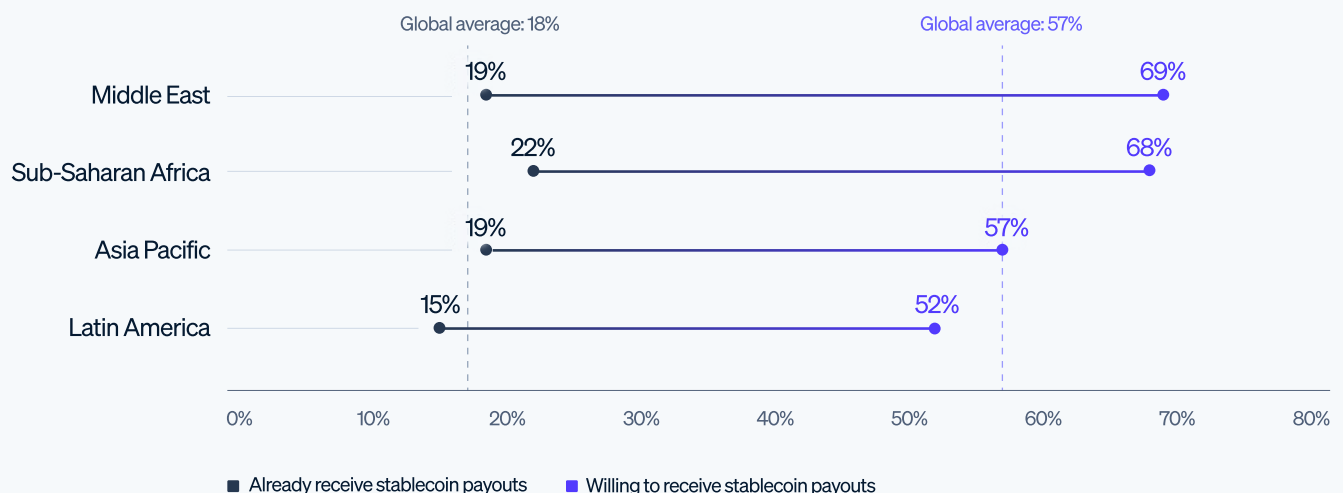
A growing number of major platforms are solving these challenges by paying global workers in **stablecoins**—digital currencies pegged to fiat like the US dollar. **DoorDash** uses the **Tempo** network to accelerate settlement—from days to seconds—in more than 40 countries. **Deel** launched a stablecoin wallet so contractors can get paid in dollars in over 150 countries. **Meta** started paying creators in Argentina, Colombia, Peru, and the Philippines in stablecoins.

This report examines survey data of more than 2,000 independent workers—gig workers, contractors, creators, freelancers, and marketplace sellers—in 20 countries across sub-Saharan Africa, Asia Pacific, Latin America, and the Middle East to understand where the opportunity is largest and in which markets workers may prefer stablecoins over traditional fiat payouts.

The stablecoin opportunity: Our global survey, conducted with Qualtrics in Q4 2025, shows a clear opportunity for platforms: 57% of respondents say they are willing to accept stablecoin payouts, but just 18% directly receive them. Offering stablecoins can bridge that gap and give workers what they're already asking for—faster payments, cheaper transfers, stable currency, and even yield on earnings.

Willingness to accept stablecoins outpaces adoption

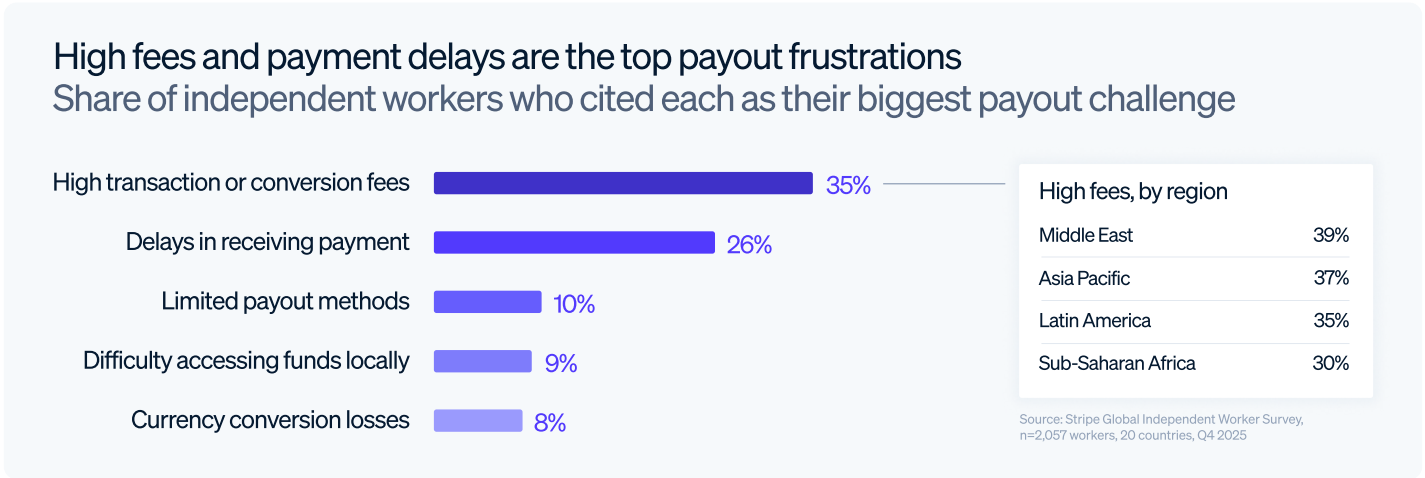
Share of independent workers, by region



Source: Stripe Global Independent Worker Survey, n=2,057 workers, 20 countries, Q4 2025

Why workers are eager for more payout options

In our survey, the cost and speed of traditional payouts are workers’ main frustrations. Thirty-five percent cited high transaction and conversion fees as their biggest payout frustration, and 26% were frustrated with delays in receiving their funds.



Cost frustrations were highest in the Middle East, with 39% citing high transaction and currency conversion fees as their single biggest payout challenge. It’s also the region with the highest interest in stablecoin payouts—69% of respondents in the Middle East are willing to accept payment in stablecoins. In sub-Saharan Africa, 68% of workers were interested, and 22% said they already receive stablecoin payments, the highest of any region.

	Traditional payment rails	Stablecoins
Speed	1–5 business days	Nearly instant settlement
Cost	International wire: \$15–\$50 per transaction ACH: \$0.20–\$1.50 per transaction Credit card: 1.5%–3.5% per transaction	<\$0.10 per transaction
Cross-border capabilities	Relies on correspondent or domestic banking system; additional FX fees	Borderless; minimal or nonexistent FX fees
Programmability	Manual interventions and settlement friction; limited API capabilities	Fully digital and programmable

Source: McKinsey & Company, “The stable door opens: How tokenized cash enables next-gen payments,” July 2025

Beyond cost and speed, workers pointed to specific regional problems that stablecoin payouts could help solve:

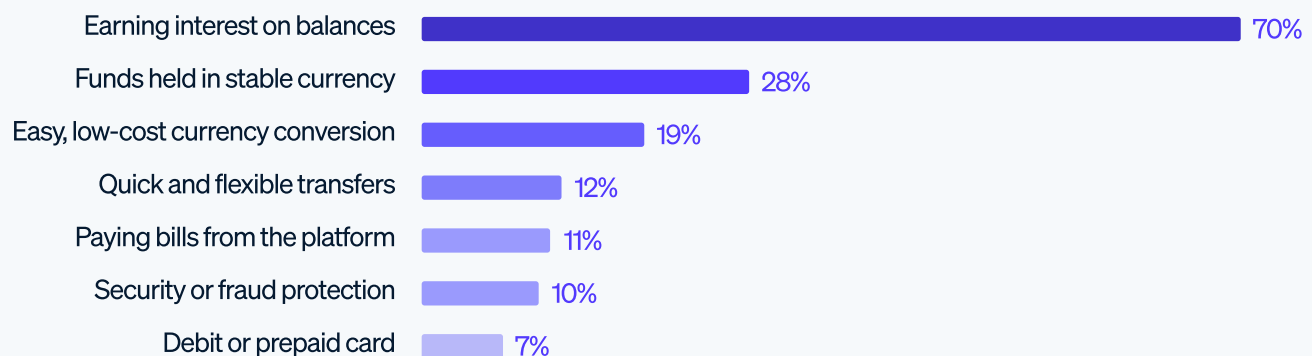
- **Currency instability in Latin America and Asia Pacific:** Thirty-two percent of workers in Latin America and 24% in Asia Pacific cite inflation protection as a top stablecoin driver. In markets like Argentina and the Philippines where local currency can fluctuate by double-digit percentages in a single year, workers want to hold dollars without requiring a US bank account.
- **Lack of bank access in sub-Saharan Africa:** Forty percent of Africa's population is **unbanked**, and 90% of all financial transactions are conducted in cash. In our survey, 72% of workers in sub-Saharan Africa already get paid through digital wallets—a workaround born from those banking barriers—and 38% want stablecoins primarily to receive payouts.
- **Cross-border remittance in the Middle East:** Fifty-three percent said sending money across borders is their primary stablecoin use case, the highest of any region. The Middle East hosts large concentrations of migrant workers, and while its **remittance corridors** are less costly than most, sending money home still costs more than 6% on average—twice the G20's 3% target.

How stablecoins can help platforms attract and retain talent

Stablecoin payouts are a powerful retention tool because they give workers what our survey shows they're asking for—more flexibility in storing, managing, and growing their money.

Workers want to earn interest on their payout balance

Top reasons for keeping earnings in a platform account, by share of independent workers



Source: Stripe Global Independent Worker Survey, n=2,057 workers, 20 countries, Q4 2025

When asked what account features are most appealing in a payout platform, 70% of workers ranked earning interest as their top choice. They want their earnings account to act like a high-yield savings account, not just a place where money lands. The next most desired features: the ability to hold stable currencies (28%), low-cost currency conversion (19%), and quick/flexible transfers or payouts directly from the platform (12%).

Global payroll and compliance platform Deel cited [currency fluctuations](#) as a key driver for its stablecoin wallet. According to Deel, in 2025, 85% of contractors in Argentina chose to be paid in US dollars rather than Argentine pesos. By getting paid directly to a stablecoin wallet, Deel's contractors can hold earnings in dollars, earn rewards, and spend worldwide inside the platform they already use to get paid.

The takeaway for platforms: workers who can easily accept, hold, grow, and convert earnings inside your platform have less reason to leave it. But a few barriers stand in the way of widespread stablecoin adoption.

What's preventing stablecoin adoption

Our research points to three obstacles preventing workers from adopting stablecoins.

Awareness

Thirty-four percent of respondents in our global worker survey said they don't understand what stablecoins are. While usage is increasing—global stablecoin payments volume reached [\\$400 billion in 2025](#), a 100% year-over-year increase—many workers don't understand their benefits and how they differ from other cryptocurrencies. Overall, workers want more education around stablecoins: when asked what would make them more likely to try or adopt stablecoins, 53% said “clear, simple instructions on how to buy, store, and use stablecoins.”

Fraud and trust concerns block stablecoin adoption

Top barriers to stablecoin use, by share of independent workers



Source: Stripe Global Independent Worker Survey, n=2,303, 20 countries, Q4 2025

Trust

Forty percent of respondents cited scams, fraud, or security concerns as the top barrier to stablecoin adoption. Thirty-nine percent said they do not know a trustworthy place to acquire stablecoins, and 35% are not confident stablecoins will keep their value. Workers in the Middle East and sub-Saharan Africa have more trust: 67% and 65%, respectively, agree that stablecoins are safe to use.

Technological complexity

Even among those who understand stablecoins, most recipients don't have a wallet. Stripe data from an ongoing platform pilot of 4,000 workers shows that 97% of participants in Latin America and Asia Pacific created a new wallet to receive stablecoin payouts—signaling few had one to begin with. Eligible workers were able to set up a [Link](#) wallet, where they can receive stablecoin payouts, withdraw instantly, or spend via card.

How Stripe can help

With Stripe, platforms and marketplaces can pay out independent workers in stablecoins in more than 100 countries and enable them to manage their finances in one place. Workers can receive dollar-denominated payouts, hold and convert to local currency, and pay out globally—all without having to set up a crypto wallet independently.

Stripe supports stablecoins across its product portfolio:

- [Link](#) enables consumers to receive stablecoins, hold a dollar-denominated balance, move funds to an external bank account, spend it via cards, and convert to local currency.
- [Stripe Treasury](#) lets businesses hold stablecoin balances, convert between fiat currencies, spend stablecoin balances with a locally issued card, and send stablecoins to crypto wallets across borders.
- [Stripe Connect](#) helps marketplaces and platforms manage compliant multiparty payouts, including cross-border settlement, compliance, and tax reporting. Businesses using Connect can send stablecoin payouts to more than 100 countries.
- [Stripe Global Payouts](#) enable businesses to send money directly to recipients in more than 160 countries via fiat and stablecoins.
- [Bridge](#) provides stablecoin orchestration APIs for onramping, offramping, and cross-border transfers, with coverage across key emerging markets.
- [Tempo](#) is the blockchain for payments, designed to facilitate high-throughput, low-cost global transactions, including machine payments.
- [Privy](#) allows developers to embed noncustodial or custodial wallets directly into their applications, enabling users to receive, hold, and transact stablecoins.

Accelerate global payouts today using [stablecoins](#) on Stripe.

Methodology

This report draws on the “Stripe Global Independent Worker Survey: Stablecoins,” a quantitative survey of 2,303 respondents across 20 countries in Latin America, Asia Pacific, sub-Saharan Africa, and the Middle East. They include Argentina, Bolivia, Brazil, Chile, Colombia, Costa Rica, India, Indonesia, Kenya, Mexico, Nigeria, Pakistan, Panama, the Philippines, Saudi Arabia, Singapore, South Africa, Thailand, Turkey, and Vietnam.

Respondents were asked how they earn income, and those who said they receive income as a gig or contract worker were classified as “independent workers.” Market prioritization was informed by a multicriteria framework evaluating stablecoin inflows and outflows, overall cryptocurrency usage, inflation rates, currency volatility (drawn from Stripe data), remittance inflows, and GDP. Not all respondents answered every question. Where noted, chart-level sample sizes (n) reflect only those who were routed to or completed a given question and may differ from the total survey population of 2,303.

The survey was conducted via Qualtrics between November 25, 2025, and December 28, 2025. Per-country sample sizes are approximately 100. Note: The survey used Qualtrics panels across emerging markets; respondents skew toward digitally literate, internet-connected populations.

